

The Cardinal’s Promise

Brief for the editor — what changed, what’s settled, what’s open

FROM ROB BRIZZI · AUGUST 2026 · MANUSCRIPT 199 PP / ~57,000 WORDS

Scott — this goes with a fresh copy of the manuscript. **The file you have is from before a round of revision**, so a few things you might otherwise spend time on are already handled. Everything below is meant to save you hours, not to fence you in; if you disagree with any of it, say so and it changes.

Already done since your copy — please don’t re-edit these

- **The ending.** The book was closing five separate times after the Epilogue. “What I’m Asking You to Do” and “Tyler and Jaye” are cut entirely; back matter between the cardinal and the standard sections went from 1,630 words to 768.
- **Chapter 28 retitled “The Detour”** (was “The Viagra of Diabetes Meds” — wrong door into the father’s death, and a joke about a named employer’s product).
- **Chapter 26** compressed by 470 words — the Hope section was a virtue list; all scenes kept, connective assertion cut.
- **Two continuity errors under load-bearing scenes:** the first pill was told twice as two different first times (Oxford 1999 is the true one; San Diego is now escalation), and Lou’s age at meeting Becky contradicted the dedication (he was forty-three, not forty-one).
- **The December timeline.** The chapter said pneumonia on the 23rd and a plan to go down “Saturday” — which fell two days after Lou died. Corrected to the truth: the plan was Friday, he died Thursday.
- **Repetition:** “showing up” cut from 62 uses to 41; “that was the whole ____” from 11 to 5; two of the five *Drives* interstitials cut because they retold scenes the book tells in full a chapter away.
- **One safety line** in Chapter 15 reworded so the passage no longer frames dying as courage.

What twenty-nine outside readers said

Two blind reader panels read the full manuscript. The findings you are most likely to hit are already known, so you don’t need to spend time surfacing them:

AGREEMENT FINDING

10 of 19	The book ended too many times — fixed
8 of 19	The middle sags: Ch. 19’s five sequential mentor portraits, Ch. 26’s catalogs. Ch. 26 done; Ch. 19 is open.
4 of 10	Quit point was inside Ch. 26 — addressed
6 of 19	Thesis-word repetition — fixed
unanimous	All ten second-round readers said the book ends at the cardinal and the ending is <i>earned</i> . Please protect the Epilogue.

Consistently praised, across every lens: the Prologue, Chapter 15 (West Palm Beach), Chapter 20 (Horacio), and Lou built out of ordinary acts.

Open — your call would help

- **Chronology.** Your note about the story bouncing between twelve, nineteen, and high school matches what a structure editor found independently: Part Four runs 2009, 2009, 2006, 2010, 2014, 2011, 2012. Straightening that is welcome.
- **Chapter 19** — five mentor biographies back to back; the cold reader nearly stopped there.
- **Chapter 9's title** claims “When I Worked for the Mob” while the chapter itself says “*I didn’t know what that meant. I still don’t.*” It also names a trade union near fraud allegations.
- **Lou is asserted, not dramatized.** Chapter 3 says he had a temper and then never shows it. Twenty-nine readers, not one saw him lose it. Horacio, by contrast, is allowed to be difficult — which is why he reads as the most alive person in the book.

One thing to settle before the hours go in

Your note said: “*Your book is not about Lou, it’s about recovery.*”

That may be right, but it isn’t a small note — the title, the subtitle, the dedication, and the marketing all currently say father. Outside readers responded most strongly to the two-father structure (“*one kept calling, the other kept coming*”). If the book’s center is going to move, better to agree on it now than to discover it forty hours in.

Rob’s current intent is that recovery is the engine and Lou is the spine — but he’d rather hear your case than assume.

The manuscript is version-controlled; every change above is reversible line by line. If a cut went too far, it can come back exactly as it was.